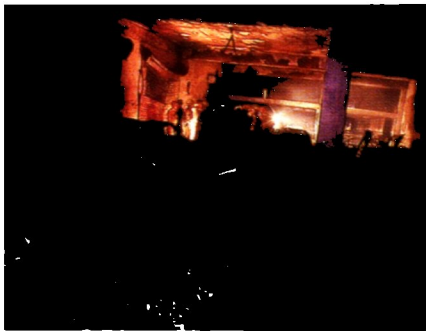


LANDMARK VERDICT



CHARRED: Burnt parking lot (left); rescue work in progress at Uphaar theatre

A decade after the Uphaar tragedy, a sessions court sentences 12, setting a legal precedent in public safety. But for the kin of the dead, it is too little too late.

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

It is possibly India's most infamous movie screening: 59 cinema goers were asphyxiated and 103 injured on June 13, 1997 when the Uphaar theatre turned into an inferno. Since then Uphaar has become synonymous with corruption and commercial interests blatantly overriding safety norms. The fire began in a malfunctioning Delhi Vidyut Board (DVB) transformer. It later spread to the cars parked nearby and later to the flammable air-conditioning ducts, which funnelled smoke into the packed hall on that Black Friday.

Ironically, most theatre goers mistook the acrid smell and wisps of smoke to be part of the special effects of the war movie *Border* flickering on the screen before them. As the smoke billowed in from the middle exit door, nearly 300 panic-stricken people in the balcony rushed to the other two exits only to discover that one had been blocked by a special eight-seater family box. Another had been bolted from the outside by the theatre staff. While the audience in the stalls escaped, the balcony with its blocked exits and shut doors turned into a gas chamber.

Now, a decade later, a sessions court verdict has held 12 persons including the owners, theatre management and



CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

TWO YEARS' IMPRISONMENT



Given to five under Section 304A for causing death due to rash & negligent act.



■ Sushil (top) and Gopal Ansal: Headed the board of directors of Ansal Theatres and Clubotels Limited.

■ Shyam Sunder Sharma and N.D. Tiwari: Administrative officers, MCD
■ H.S. Panwar: Delhi Fire Service

MAXIMUM 10 YEARS' IMPRISONMENT

Given to four officials of Uphaar theatre and three others under Section 304 for culpable homicide not amounting to murder.

■ Radha Kishan Sharma: Manager
■ Nirmal Singh Chopra: Assistant Manager
■ Ajit Choudhary: Assistant Manager
■ Manmohan Unniyal: Gatekeeper
■ Brij Mohan Satija and Anand Kumar Gera: DVB inspectors
■ Bir Singh: Senior Fitter